

**DETERMINE CAREFULLY THE MEANING OF WORDS**



When the Old Testament was written, it was written in ancient Hebrew.

Ancient Hebrew looks like this:

בְּרֵאשִׁית בָּרָא אֱלֹהִים אֶת הַשָּׁמַיִם וְאֶת הָאָרֶץ:



Start at this end.

Read from right to left.

When the New Testament was written, most of it was written in ancient Greek.

Ancient Greek looks like this:

Ἐν ἀρχῇ ἦν ὁ λόγος, καὶ ὁ λόγος ἦν πρὸς τὸν θεόν, καὶ θεὸς ἦν ὁ λόγος.

Start at this end.



Read from left to right.

The Scriptures have been translated into many different languages.

Translating can be complicated.

A Translator needs to understand **Grammar**. What do the rules of language use tell me about this word? What kind of word is it?

A Translator needs to understand **Etymology**. When was a word first used and what did it mean then? What other words are built upon the original word and what do they mean?

A Translator needs to understand **General Usage**. How did people usually use this word? How has the meaning of this word changed over time? Does it have more than one meaning? Does it mean different things in different situations?

Here is an example of how it works.

I took some classes on Biblical Hebrew. In my third class we started learning to translate scripture. One day I was translating Genesis 15.

The story was about Abram (later named Abraham). God told Abram to go outside of his tent and look at the stars. He told Abram that his descendants (his children's children's children...) would be as many as the stars. Abram believed God and it was accounted to him as righteousness. God also promised to give him the land in which he was living. Abram said, "How shall I know that I will inherit it?" God told him to sacrifice some animals. So Abram did.

Then I came to this verse.

וַיֵּרֶד הָעֵיט עַל־הַפְּגָרִים וַיֵּשֶׁב אֹתָם אֲבָרָם:

I knew that the vultures had flown down on Abram's sacrifices. But there was a word that I didn't know.

וַיֵּשֶׁב

*Grammar:* The rules of grammar told me that Abram caused the vultures to do something. What did he cause them to do?

*Etymology:* I needed to find the three letter Root Word so I could look it up in the Hebrew Lexicon (a kind of dictionary). The grammar rules made me think that the Root was:

יָשַׁב

I looked it up in the Lexicon. There was only one definition: Blow. Did Abram cause the birds to blow?



That didn't make sense! Did I pick the wrong root?

*General Usage:* Down below the definition there were examples of how the word was used in other parts of the Bible and how they were translated. I found the form of the word I was looking for. It had two Scriptures listed.

One was Psalm 147:18 *"He causes His wind to blow."*

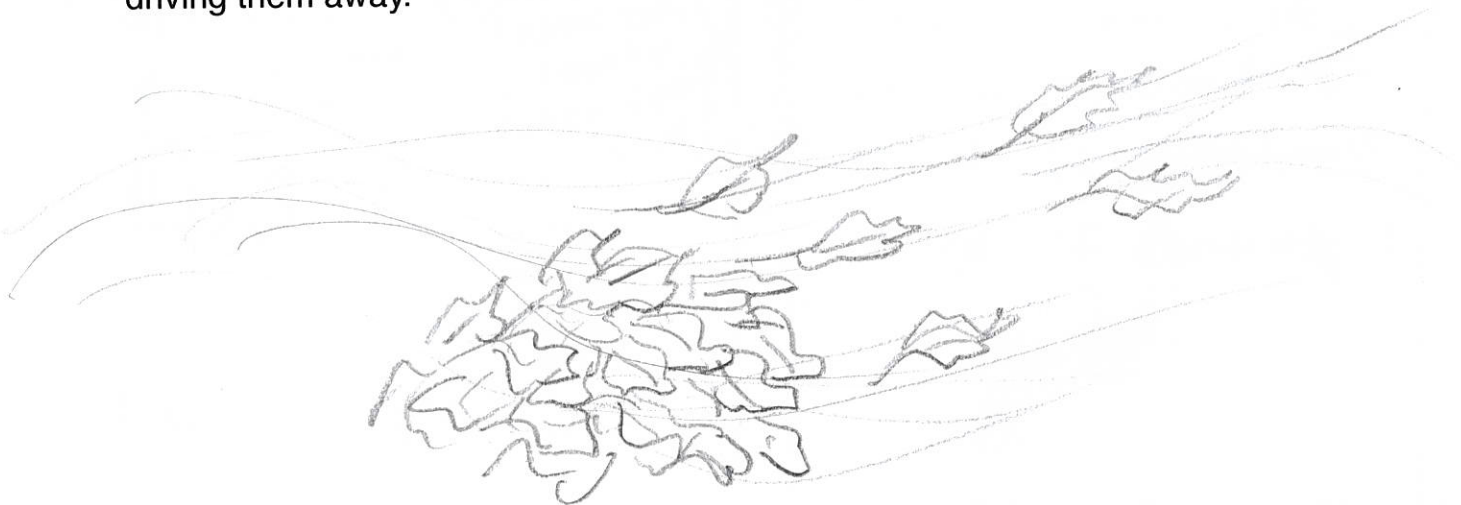
This verse was saying that God causes His wind to blow. That made sense.

The other was my verse, Genesis 15:11 *"and he drove them away"*  
That made sense!

Same Word. Same Root. Same Grammar. Different definition. Why? Words can have more than one meaning. They may mean different things in different situations. You know Abram didn't make the birds blow like they were blowing up balloons or bubbles. What did he do? He drove them away from his sacrifices!



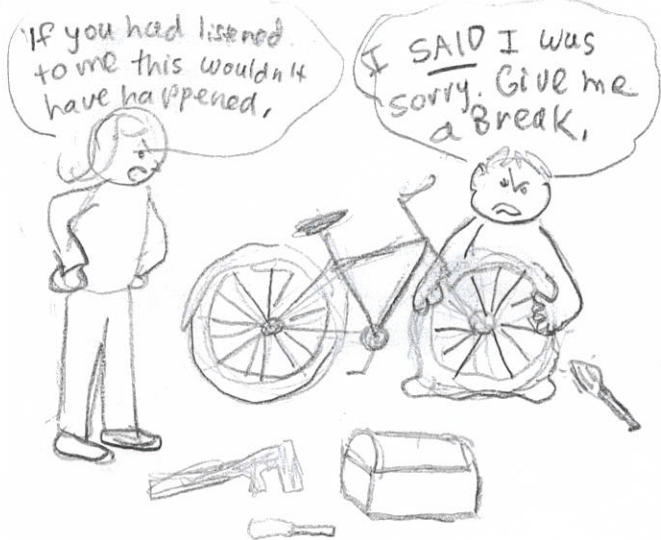
Word meanings can change over time as people use them. How did "blow" get to be "drive away". Well what happens when the wind blows? It blows things like leaves and chaff away. Abram was acting like the wind when he drove away the birds. The Lexicon suggested that Abram may have made a blowing sound while driving them away.





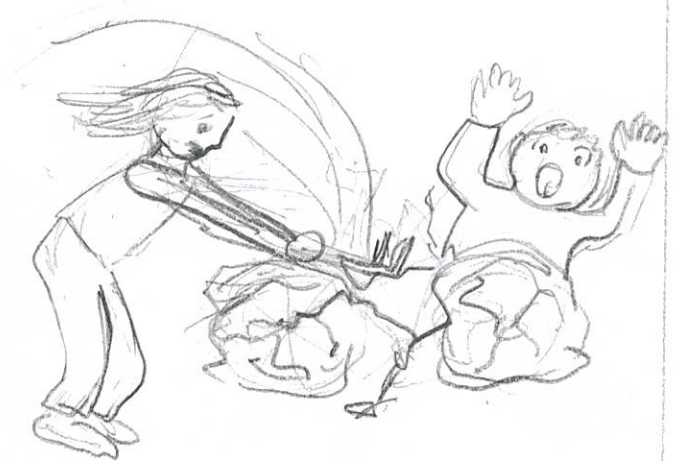
Some English words have different meanings in different situations

WORD: "BREAK" =



The situation in which a word is used is another kind of Context,

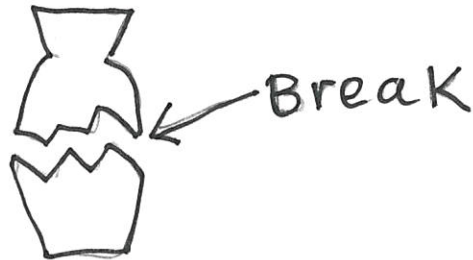
Silly things could happen  
if we ignore context.



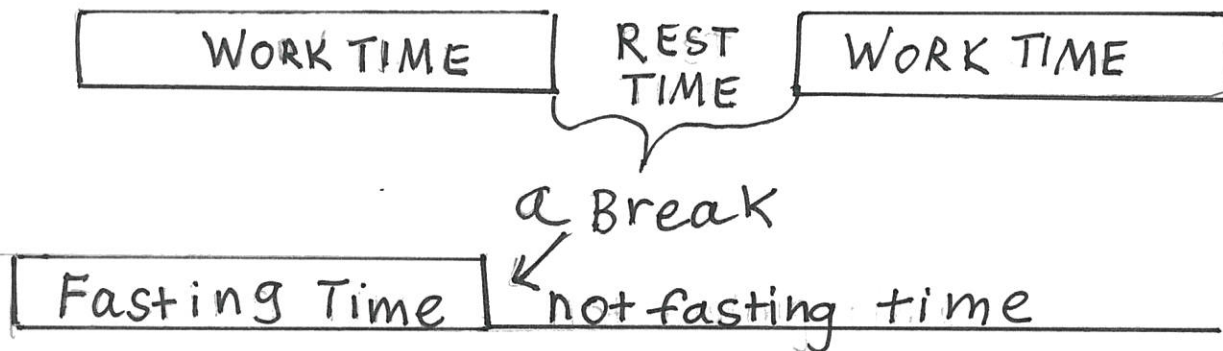


The phrase "Give me a break" is an **idiom**. A word or a phrase becomes an idiom when it is used in an unexpected way, to mean something different than the words used usually mean.

"Break" is usually used to tell when something is smashed or split in two like the vase in the first picture. You "break" something in two or in pieces. A crack in a vase or a wall could be called "a break" in the vase or wall.



The children working in the garden stop working so they can have cookies and lemonade. Then they will start working again. Their working time has been split in two so that they can rest and eat. There is a "break" in the time. Brother Martin breaks off from his fasting time (not eating) and begins eating again.



But when the boy says, "Give me a break," he is not asking the girl to smash something or to split it in two (especially NOT the bike). He is asking her to be nice to him and stop telling him how stupid he was. It has nothing to do with smashing or splitting anything.

In English we use all kinds of idioms.

"It's raining cats and dogs," doesn't mean that there are dogs and cats falling out of the sky. It means it is raining very hard.



If you say that your sister "spilled the beans" you don't mean that she actually spilled beans on the floor. You mean that she told someone something that was supposed to be kept secret.



Some words or phrases in the Bible may be used to mean something different from what we would normally think. In Matthew 7:15 Jesus says to watch out for false prophets. "They come to you in sheep's clothing, but inwardly are ferocious wolves." He doesn't mean that these false prophets will actually wear sheep's wool. He means that they will seem friendly and harmless but are really wicked and shouldn't be trusted.



Scripture word:

WORLD

Jesus: "For God so loved the world that He gave His only begotten Son...."

John 3:16

Apostle John: "Do not love the world or the things in the world."

1 John 2:12



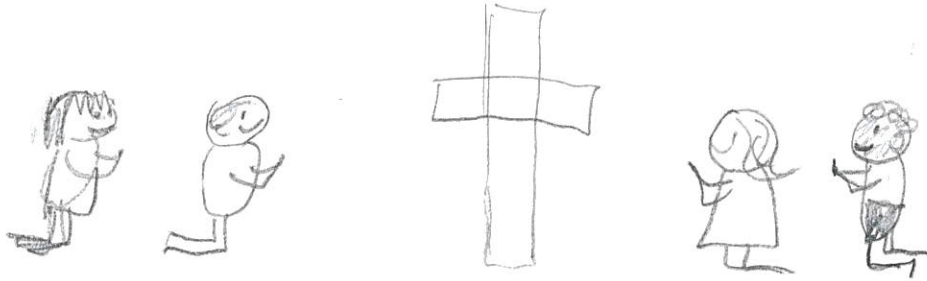
Context can Help

In John 3:11-21, Jesus is telling Nicodemus how someone is Born Again.

Jesus says that God sent His only begotten Son into the world to save it. The person who believes in the Son will not perish but have eternal Life.



When Jesus says God loves the world, He means God loved people in the world enough to send His son to save them.



In 1 John 2:15-17, the apostle John lists 3 things in the world that we should not love.

The Lust of the flesh



Lust of the eyes



PRIDE of Life



When the apostle John says not to love the world, he is talking about the sin in the world. Sin is selfish. Lust is when we love the things in the world so much that we disobey God or hurt other people to get them.



A good dictionary is useful in helping to understand Grammar, Etymology, and General Usage. A dictionary tells you what part a word can play in grammar (noun, verb, adjective, adverb etc.). It tells you what the word originally meant, what it means now in different contexts, and how it is used in idioms. Learning how to use a dictionary will help you carefully determine the meaning of words.